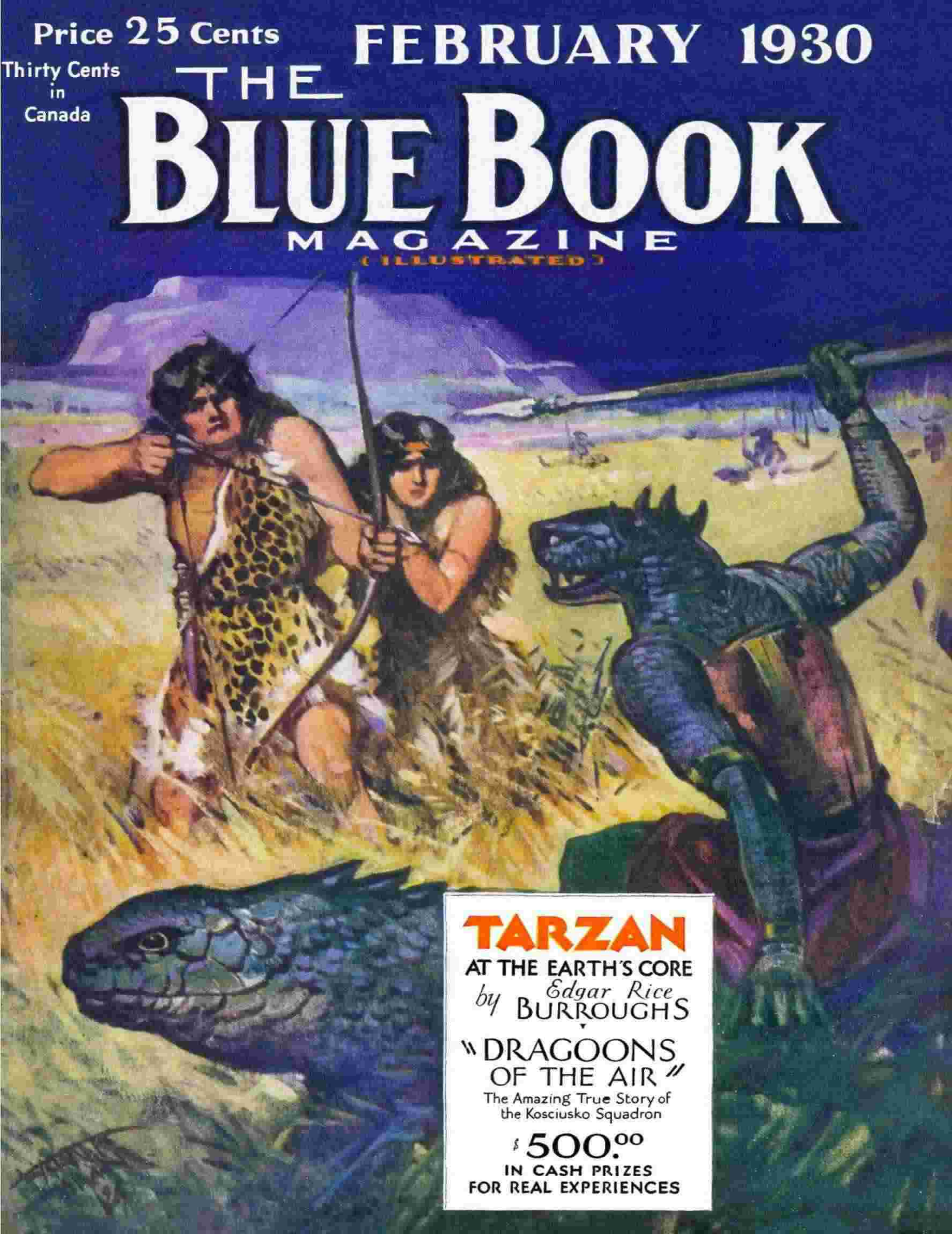




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FEBRUARY 1930

THE BLUE BOOK

MAGAZINE

(ILLUSTRATED)

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by *Edgar Rice*
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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE COAST
GUARDSMAN ***

*“I aint begun to fight!” declared the man who was to
become Number One surfman. And then he started*

in!



The Coast Guardsman

*“That feller run like a deer when we surrounded him
... I put a bullet in that smuggler’s leg--an’ down he
went!”*

THE COAST GUARDSMAN

By W. E. Carleton

Illustrated by William Molt

“Hell’s bells! You—thutty year old, an’ five of it in the service, an’ you aint discovered yit that the coast guard aint a substitute for the old ladies’ home! Devil of a prospec’ *I’ve* got—Jansen transferred to Sandy Holler station, an’ you in line to step into his shoes. *You* to be Number One surfman!”

“But, Cap’n Cole—” protested the fair-haired, sun-bronzed young Number Two surfman, squaring his sturdy shoulders.

“If the rum-runners o’ Cape Cod hear you’ve replaced Jansen,” the commander of Santuck station cut in, “they’ll declare a half holiday to

celebrate. The story o' the latest *Seabright* affair night 'fore last will likely go the length an' breadth o' the Cape, if it don't go further."

"You don't need to remind me o' *that*," Aubrey Sears, Number Two surfman, diligently polished the brasswork of the beachcart, and the keen black eyes of Cap Cole roved through the apparatus shed—looking for something else to find fault with, Aubrey presumed. "But sometimes, Cap'n, things aint always what they seem—'specially on a dark night on Salt Marsh."

"Aint what they seem? What d'yuh mean by that?"

"Jist that. All I've got to say is it's a pity you didn't see with yer own eyes what really happened, an' not have to take Jansen's word for it."

Cap Cole's heavy black mustache and shaggy eyebrows were scarcely darker than the thundercloud which passed over his square face. Menacingly he hunched his massive shoulders forward.

"You tryin' to make me out a liar?" he roared.

"No—if I was, I'd tell you point-blank, Cap'n," Sears clarified his position in the matter. "But I *do* accuse Jansen o' lyin', though I know it wont do me no good. When that smuggler from the *Seabright* run acrost the marsh towards me—"

"You let him keep on runnin'—an' he'd be runnin' yit if Jansen hadn't put a bullet in his leg," finished the Captain. "An' I don't want for you to call my Number One surfman a liar in my presence, Sears. He's rankin' above you, an' I'll take his word as final until I'm shown proof that'll change my opinion. When you git through with that job on the beachcart," he shifted the subject, "go up in the tower an' touch up the brasswork there." The Santuck commander turned on his heel and stalked out of the apparatus shed.

Sears sighed resignedly, and energetically applied a soft strip of flannel to the shining metal of the beachcart. Cap's April-morning tirade was only a repetition of the mild abuse to which he had subjected the young surfman of late. It was beginning to keep the conscientious Aubrey awake nights, preying on his mind during precious hours when he should be resting for

patrol duty on desolate Santuck beach, or getting in a wink of sleep after such a patrol in preparation for the next day's work. And the duties of a member of the Santuck crew were strenuous the year round, for that strip of coast had come to be the rendezvous of the various specialists in smuggling who were operating extensively on Cape Cod.

The independent Yankee blood of Aubrey Sears had reached the boiling point, but it hadn't boiled over—yet. Before he met Mamie Weston two years ago, he would have kicked over the traces, told Cap Cole where he could get off, and consigned Santuck and its highly efficient crew to Davy Jones. He was able-bodied, big-boned, hard as nails, and although the coast-guard job was the only line of work he was familiar with, he could find employment inland—something less to his liking, but productive of sufficient funds to support him. Time and again he was tempted to inform Cap that he was through.

But his reward at Santuck for taking Cap's abuse unwhimperingly would quite probably be the Number One surfman's job. He was in direct line for promotion, and under his skin Cap wasn't half so savage as he appeared to be on the surface, for he had always recommended his crew for promotion without fear or favor according to seniority in the service. The trouble in the *Seabright* affair was that Cap believed Jansen because of the latter's rating above Aubrey. Cap's discipline was maintained by his backing the Number One surfman in all matters.

On the assumption that he would be thus promoted, Aubrey and Mamie had planned to marry. She was a pretty, lightbrown-haired and blue-eyed beam of irresponsible human sunshine who lived with her widowed mother in Howesport village.

On one side of the mantel of the cottage parlor where Aubrey and she could usually be found when he was off duty, hung a portrait of George Washington; balancing it on the opposite side was suspended one of Aubrey in his uniform.

Members of the Santuck crew were always welcome at the Widow Weston's, for her husband had been keeper of Santuck station in the days when it was a unit of the life-saving service. He had died a hero at the wreck of the *David Rothwell*—one of the unsung martyrs of the grand old

crews of Cape Cod life-savers who have died in vain attempts to rescue their shipwrecked fellow-men.

But during the past few weeks Jansen had rather overstepped the conventions of that hospitality by spending the greater part of his time off duty at the widow's. Well enough Aubrey knew the nature of the attraction. But Mamie had declared to Aubrey that she detested the surfman Jansen. And Aubrey, putting his trust in that honest-eyed, straightforward new convert to flapperism who had promised to marry him, banished his jealousy. After one of Jansen's calls at the widow's, however, Aubrey always glanced at his portrait on the parlor wall to make sure it was still there. He had a suspicion that Jansen had a way with women.

That night Aubrey donned his best clothes, slipped his automatic pistol into his hip pocket—a precaution Santuck men always took because of numerous threats they received anonymously from the smuggling gentry—and trudged over the sandy road to Howesport village, two miles away. He had swapped his day off with surf man Paty—but not the night, for Mamie would be expecting him.

She was. She ushered him into the parlor as usual, and took a seat beside him on the sofa. But she didn't seem like her ordinarily gay and unburdened self. Aubrey couldn't remember ever having noticed that she was worried before.

“What's the matter, Mamie?” he asked.

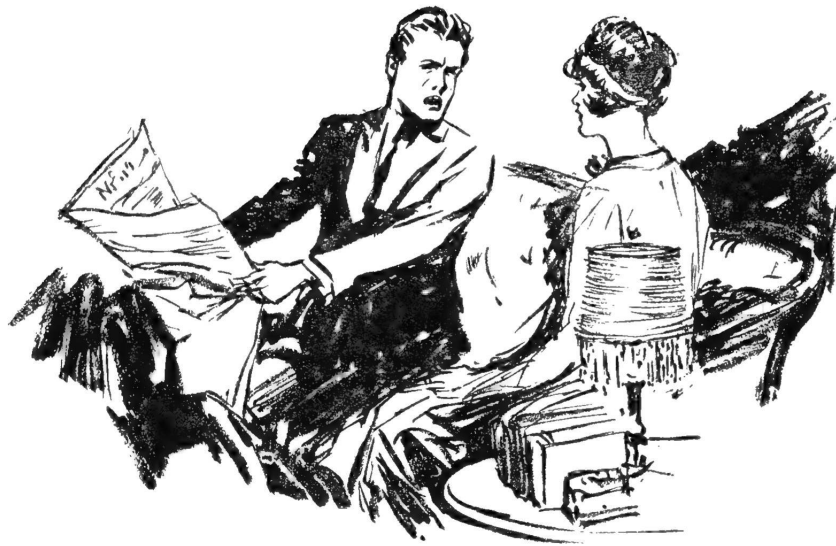
Mamie did not answer immediately. Then: “Did you see today's Boston paper, Aubrey?”

“No! What's in it?” But he already suspected.

And his suspicions were correct. Mamie showed it to him—the account of how the outlaw schooner *Seabright* had slipped past the cordon of coast-guard cutters off the back side of Cape Cod again—how the Santuck crew had been called out by Surfman Hubbard, who sighted the vessel on his patrol to the halfway house between Santuck and Sandy Hollow stations. How the crew had pounced on the landing-party from the schooner and captured the smuggled cargo of whisky brought ashore in the speedboat

from the *Seabright*, scared off a shore party that had come from an automobile evidently to receive the contraband beverage, and cut off one of the landing-party before he could escape with his shipmates in the speedboat.

But after finishing that part of the narrative, Aubrey's gray eyes fairly shot sparks, his coppery complexion darkened, and the newspaper shook in his strong calloused fingers.



Aubrey's gray eyes fairly shot sparks. "All the rest of that's a lie!" he declared in a husky voice.

"All the rest o' that's a lie!" he declared in a husky voice. "That feller run like a deer when we surrounded him—run straight for me. I run to meet him, an' he up an' veered off the other direction. Jansen was standin' plumb in front o' him. But when Jansen seen him bearin' down on him, he let out a screech an' turned an' run. Run away from him—I swear to God! An' when I seen that, I put a bullet in the smuggler's leg—an' down he went, moanin'."

"But where was Cap Cole an' the other Santuck boys all that time?" queried Mamie.

“Comin’ up from the shore—closin’ in on the smuggler. We was in a wide circle—”

“But didn’t Cap see it—see who done the shootin’?”

Aubrey sniffed contemptuously. “See it? Huh—if Jansen hadn’t knowed Cap couldn’t see it, he wouldn’t ’a’ lied like he did. ’Twas dark as a pocket on Salt Marsh. If Jansen hadn’t been so close to me, I wouldn’t ’a’ reco’nized *him* until he let out that screech when the smuggler put for him. But when that smuggler went down with my bullet in his leg! Lord, *then* Jansen was Johnny-on-the-spot. He was bendin’ over that smuggler an’ holdin’ down his arms before the rest o’ the crew come up. An’ ’twas then he told Cap his story—jist like it’s printed in that damn’ newspaper—taken, likely, from the report Cap sent to the superintendent.”

He crushed the paper in his powerful hands and hurled it to the floor.

Mamie laid a soothing little hand on his cheek and looked pityingly into his angry eyes.

“I know how you must feel, Aubrey dear,” she sympathized. “An’ I believe you—ev’ry word. Jansen *is* mean—I can see that in his eyes when he comes here. The worst of it is, it makes you out to be a coward. An’ I know you’d never be a coward, Aubrey.”

“Jansen’ll pay for this!” stormed Aubrey. “I wish I hadn’t been so meek for discipline’s sake when he told that lie to Cap. I should ’a’ made him swaller it right there on Salt Marsh. But I’ll do it tonight—discipline be damned! He’ll take back ev’ry word, even if I’m kicked out o’ the service for bearin’ him up!”

“And then when would we be married?” plaintively asked Mamie. “What would become of your record in the service? Thrown away! Even if Cap should be mean enough to hold you back from promotion now, another opportunity’ll come up where you can make a better name for yourself, one that Jansen can’t damage with his lies. An’ accordin’ to all accounts, they’s an opportunity here right now.”

Aubrey looked at her inquiringly. “What d’yuh mean, opportunity?” he asked.

“Amos Swift was in yesterday afternoon. He claims they’s smugglin’ goin’ on in Howesport harbor, right in front o’ his house.”

“Pshaw! I don’t b’lieve it!” Aubrey ridiculed the idea. “It aint likely smugglers’d be so bold. Amos an’ Cap Cole have been at swords’-points for years. I wouldn’t put it past Amos to start a story like that to make out that Cap’s asleep on his job.”

“Cap *is*!” declared Mamie. “None of the Santuck men ever patrol Howesport harbor now’days. When Father was in command at the station, he had it patrolled just like the main beach.”

“Yeah—but times have changed since then,” Aubrey defended his superior. “That Howesport harbor patrol took us two miles out o’ the reg’lar patrol—we hated it. That’s *one* service Jansen done at the station. He convinced Cap ’twas a waste o’ time, an’ Cap agreed with him. The result was we got orders from the superintendent not to include Howesport harbor in our post.”

“Then no wonder the smugglers are takin’ advantage of it!” retorted Mamie. “Amos says you can see ’em there any foggy night like tonight. He thinks they’re from the *Seabright*.”

“Why doesn’t Amos report it, then?” Aubrey asked indignantly. “If not to Cap, to one o’ the rest of us.”

“Aubrey, do you s’pose Amos wants trouble? Those smugglers might murder him an’ Emma, livin’ apart from the village like they do. You mustn’t even mention that I told you this, Aubrey, because Amos has left it with you to do somethin’ about it yourself without lettin’ Cap into it. He knows how Cap holds you down. It’s a chance for you, Aubrey, to capture those smugglers an’ get full credit for it yourself without Cap dictatin’ to you. Don’t you see?”

Aubrey saw. But not a chance to make a hero of himself. If those men Amos had reported were real smugglers, there was a possibility that Cap had a

special reason for urging the discontinuance of the Howesport harbor patrol. Though Cap appeared to be the soul of honor, one never could tell.

If Aubrey should interfere with such an enterprise in which Cap was directly concerned, a fine chance he would have of winning promotion, dependingly largely, as he was, on Cap's recommendation! Then too, he knew the crew of the *Seabright* were about as hard a bunch of cutthroats as the Lord ever put breath into. Jansen's flight on Salt Marsh from one of them had been discreet if not valiant.

"It's foggy tonight," Mamie reminded him. "There couldn't be a better night to jump on them. An' after that piece in the Boston paper, Aubrey—"

"Amos an' Emma are nervous," he protested. "Livin' alone like they do apart from the village, they prob'ly imagine—"

"They *don't* imagine!" Mamie vigorously stamped her small foot. "The least you can do is to investigate. Are you—afraid, Aubrey?"

"Afraid? Course I aint afraid! If old Amos wants me to soothe his nerves by goin' down there an' lookin' the ground over, I can do *that* much to pacify him. I'll walk back to the station that way after I leave here, an'—"

"Let's not wait till then. Aubrey," Mamie pleaded. "Let's go *now*!"

Aubrey looked at her through narrowed eyes. "You aint in on this, Mamie," he declared. "You'll stay right here. If Amos *shouldn't* be misrepresentin' it, an' they turned out to be real smugglers from the *Seabright*, it'd be no place for you when they ketch me spyin' on 'em."

"I *am* goin'! I'll go to Amos' an' call on Emma. You can escort me there, then go down to the landin' below the house. We'll watch from the upstairs window an' telephone the station if you need help. Only I hope you wont need it, Aubrey. I hope you can do it all yourself so's Cap an' Jansen wont come into it."

"A lot you'll see from the upstairs winder, a thick night like this," scoffed Aubrey. "But if you'd rather go prowlin' round Howesport harbor than entertain me my night off—"

"Aubrey, you know better'n that!" she rebuked him. "I'm doin' all this because—well, I'm sort of ashamed of that piece in the paper. An' I want

you to show ev'ryone in Howesport that you aint a coward an' never was one."

"Well, then come on!" Aubrey consented. Mamie ran upstairs, told her mother she was going to Emma's, put on her wraps, and with Aubrey went out into the night.

Through the fog they walked down the sandy road to the harbor, talking in half-whispers, Mamie hurrying three steps to his one to keep up with him. The village clock dolefully tolled eight, its distant tones sounding more funereal than ever in the leaden atmosphere.

They branched off at the side road to the two-story Swift homestead set on a wooded hill overlooking Swift's Landing on the sheltered little beach below. A light burned downstairs in the parlor.

"Wait here till I'm inside," whispered Mamie, reassuringly squeezing his hand. "Then go to the landin'. If you need help, Aubrey, shout. We'll be listenin', an' we'll telephone the station if you holler. Amos'll come down to help you while the crew's gittin' here."

Aubrey laughed under his breath. Amos! A lot of help that timid old man would be! Aubrey waited until the door of the ark on the hill opened and closed, then descended the path to the landing.

Tiny waves lapped the fog-shrouded beach. Across the narrow strip of water—not much wider than Salt Marsh Creek at high tide—two unoccupied summer cottages bulked in the fog. To their right twinkled the kitchen light of Reuben Nickerson's farmhouse, and a restless cow mooed in the stable behind it. A fine place for smugglers to operate! Why, they'd be just as likely to run their contraband ashore directly in front of Santuck station under the very noses of the crack crew of Cape Cod!

Lord—if the boys at the station ever learned that he'd snooped around looking for smugglers at Swift's Landing, he'd never hear the last of it! It would be a standing joke at the station.

Aubrey withdrew from the beach to the stunted pines of the upland, and seated himself on an overturned dory. Far down the harbor mouth the fog whistle of Narrow Point lighthouse groaned intermittently. There was a chill

in the air—a damper, clammier cold than he experienced in his patrols on the wider, more exposed stretches of Santuck beach.

The drone of the fog whistle and the continual *lap-lap* of the waves lulled him until he was half asleep. The village clock struck ten. Somewhere out on the Atlantic outside Howesport harbor a motorboat chugged. One of the coast-guard flotilla, most likely, combing the waters inside the three-mile limit for the elusive *Seabright*.

Suddenly he arose from his seat and strained his eyes at the landing. Out of the thickness loomed the bow of a dory. And astern of that dory rode another. Two men in each, one rowing, the other standing in the stern. And the oars of those dories were muffled!

Aubrey withdrew deeper into the stunted pines—just in time, for a flashlight from the leading dory played on the beach, and a deep voice, slightly hushed, sang out: “All right—straight ahead!”

The prow of the first dory scraped on the shore; then the second dory came to rest on the sand beside it. The occupants of both boats stepped into the water, and their sea-boots splashed as the dories were drawn up higher.

“Hand us a crate, thar, Russ!” the deep voice called out. “We’ve got a few more lobsters here ’n you have, I cal’late.”

A big arm shot up from a huge lumbering body, and with a thud a hand proportionately large snatched a flying crate out of the air. Carefully he and his smaller companion filled it with lobsters from the bottom of the dory, while the smaller men of the other dory lugged several lobster-laden crates ashore.



*The watching Aubrey grumbled to himself. Amos’
“smugglers” were harmless lobstermen!*

“I might ’a’ known ’twould turn out like this!” the watching Aubrey grumbled to himself. For Amos’ “smugglers” were old Nathan Holway and his three sons, harmless, industrious lobstermen who minded their own business—which was more than Amos could say of himself. And to put Aubrey in an even more ludicrous light if his presence there were detected, they were cousins of Jansen.

The young surfman took a step back, to put more pines between himself and the beach. But in doing so he stepped on an empty bottle, and it burst with a loud tinkle under his boots.

“What the hell was that?” exclaimed Nathan, and the flashlight’s ray penetrated the pines in which Aubrey was concealed.

“Thar he is—some one hidin’ in them pines!” the nasal tenor of Russ Holway rang out. “Come out o’ that thicket, you! We see yuh!”

“I’ll be damned!” shouted his brother Enoch. “It’s Aubrey Sears!”

Recognized, Aubrey stepped out of his hiding-place and walked boldly down to the landing. “Good ev’nin’,” he saluted the lobstermen. “Kinder thick, aint it?”

“What’re ye doin’, snoopin’ round an’ spyin’ on us?” belligerently roared old Nathan. “Can’t honest folks ’arn a livin’ ’thout some damned coast-guard comin’ two miles off’n his post to peek at us?”

“P’raps he’s lookin’ for that feller he run away from on Salt Marsh,” suggested Enoch, and his two brothers snickered.

That made Aubrey’s fighting blood heat up. “No matter why I’m here,” he defied them, resolved to maintain his dignity even though he felt like a fool. And he seized upon the salient feature of their landing: “You might tell me why you was rowin’ with muffled oars.”

“Hear the brave bully boy o’ Santuck!” derided Russ. “He’s puttin’ us under cross-examination. I don’t know as it’s any o’ his business why—”

“Shut up!” Nathan silenced his smart-aleck son. “This spotter’s a low-down, cowardly whelp, but he’s a officer o’ the Fed’ral Gover’mint, an’ must be treated with respec’ for the uniform he wears if nawthin’ else, even if he aint wearin’ it now,” he added suggestively. “The reason we muffled our oars, Mr. Coast Guard,” he explained with mock courtesy, “is that we didn’t want to distarb Amos Swift an’ Emma, bein’s how we was kep’ out later’n usual by a strong tide after we’d hauled our lobster pots.”

“Does that satisfy ye?” asked Fred, the youngest brother, nastily. “If it don’t—”

“Close yer damned trap!” bellowed Nathan. And he turned again to Aubrey. “Some day ye’ll git yer fool head busted, nosin’ round whar ye’ve no call to be prowlin’,” he warned. “I’m goin’ to see Cap Cole ’bout this!”

“An’ seein’s how you’re wearin’ no uniform,” invited Russ, “I’d like to take ye on for a little go right here, now, bare knuckles. I’d like nawthin’ better’ll to fix ye up so’s ye wouldn’t have no ambition to bother any more honest fishermen or runaway smugglers.”

Aubrey slipped out of his overcoat and the jacket of his best gray suit, and threw them on the beach. “I’ll accommodate ye, Russ Holway!” he shouted, assuming a defensive fighting attitude in which he had acquired a little skill by boxing with Surfman Paty for recreation during leisure moments at the station. “Come on!” he accepted the fisherman’s challenge.

But Nathan stepped between them. “They’ll be no fist-fightin’ here!” he declared. “Not but what you can lick him, Russ, but I don’t trust skulkin’ coast guards that are licensed to carry firearms, specially if they’re gittin’ the wust of it. Now, little coast-guard boy,” he taunted Aubrey, “run along back to the station. It’s late, an’ me an’ my boys want to git a night’s rest ’fore termorrer.”

“To hell with you an’ your rest!” retorted Aubrey. “You may be law-abidin’, but you seem to forgit that it’s a coast-guard man you’re makin’ fun of. An’ now that you’ve showed the service so little respec’, I’m goin’ to assert my authority jist to show you who’s boss here. You can postpone goin’ to bed until I’ve had a look at your lobsters—an’ a good long look, too, by Godfrey!”

“Damned if ye will!” roared Nathan. “You aint in uniform. Here—git back from that crate!”—as Aubrey bent and began to paw through the lobsters in it.

Nathan rushed at Aubrey, but the surfman jumped nimbly to one side.

“I’ll warn ye—it’s the United States Gover’mint you’re foolin’ with—not me personal!” Aubrey cautioned the big fisherman.

Nathan stepped back. “Thar’s my dory,” he stood his ground, pointing to the nearest boat, his face black with fury. “Now, young feller, I’ll invite ye to tech my lobsters. I’ll see whether a young sprout who aint in uniform’ll s’arch my property or not. If ye tech that dory, ye’ll do it over my dead body!”

For a few seconds Aubrey hesitated. He knew he was nominally within his authority, uniform or no uniform. Nor did the colossal strength and fighting reputation of Nathan deter him. But he fully realized that no matter what course of action he pursued now, he would emerge the loser. Public sentiment would favor the Holways if they administered a sound thrashing to him. And Cap would be sure to reprimand him for such interference with law-abiding citizens, if not to take steps to have him dropped from the service altogether.

But on the other hand, if he refused to search the dory, the Holways would advertise their triumph, and he would be branded an even greater coward than Jansen’s lie made him out to be.

In the midst of his reflections, while Nathan and his sons stood tense and silent eagerly waiting for his next move, a twig snapped in the upland. Nathan looked in that direction, and so did Aubrey. The gleam of the flashlight disclosed Mamie, Amos and Emma hiding there, partly shielded by the scrawny pines.

“Mamie—go back to the house!” shouted Aubrey.

But Mamie stepped out of her partial shelter, Emma following her on to the beach, while Amos scrambled up the steep path in precipitate retreat to the house.

“What are you waitin’ for, Aubrey?” asked Mamie, her eyes flashing, her voice shrill with excitement. “Aint you goin’ to search that dory?”

Nathan laughed clownishly. “I cal’late your hero’s thinkin’ better of it, Miss Weston,” he chuckled. “He knows tormented well that if he gits hurt doin’ it, Cap Cole’ll back me an’ my boys up.”

“Then you’re goin’ to let Cap Cole scare you out o’ doin’ your duty, Aubrey?” Mamie’s tone was ironically sweet. “Oh, if my father was only here! I know what *he’d* do!”

Aubrey clenched his fists, took a step forward—and another. He knew what doughty old Cap Weston would do if he were alive and placed in such a predicament. The hero of the wreck of the *David Rothwell* would do what he had set out to do, or die in the attempt!

Straight for the dory Aubrey marched determinedly. He heard Nathan’s bellow as he and his sons rushed to the attack.

Aubrey jumped back in time to avoid the headlong charge of Nathan, but in doing so he collided with Russ. The eldest son had not recovered from the impact when he received a terrific punch just above his waistline, and he doubled up gasping for breath. Aubrey whirled on Fred and planted a wicked wallop on that bewildered youth’s jaw. Like an infuriated bull goaded by its tormentors in the ring, Aubrey faced Enoch, and after a short exchange of blows, put a damper on the second son’s ardor by delivering a haymaker to his nose.

Panting from his exertion, he turned to Nathan, who bore down on him with lowered head and flying fists. The surfman sidestepped—but not soon

enough, for one of the fisherman's blows found its mark on Aubrey's chin. Half dazed though he was, Aubrey countered with a right to the giant's jaw, which caused no more perceptible damage than birdshot to the hide of a rhinoceros.

From that instant on, the fight was a rough-and-tumble, free-for-all, and general rough-house. No chance for Aubrey to display any of the science he had acquired boxing with Paty. He struck out blindly, saved himself from his attackers by quick footwork, oppressed from all sides at once. Blows light and heavy landed on his cheeks, chin, and jaws, while he danced and dodged in the center of the melee, confused by the odds against him, but keeping his antagonists on the jump by avoiding dirty tactics on their part like tripping or kicking.

Then as they edged in closer, he broke through the ring surrounding him and ran a few yards up the beach, where he faced them again. He launched a right at Enoch which staggered that aggressive little bunch of wiry sinews. But at the same time the coast-guard received a crushing punch on the cheek from Russ. He managed, however, to dodge past Enoch and escape from the circle which was forming around him again. And there, his back to the harbor, some fifty yards upshore from the dories, once more he defied the four oncoming fishermen.

Aubrey was breathing hard, his nose bleeding, cheeks and lips cut, one eye closed, and his shirt flapping in shreds. Time and again he broke clear; and the scene of battle shifted frequently up and down the beach.

After one of Aubrey's eel-like escapes, Nathan shoved his sons back and faced the surfman alone. "Got—enough?" the huge lobsterman panted, his leathery face daubed with blood, his thick lips split.

"Hell—no! I aint begun to fight yit!" Aubrey defied him. "Try it ag'in! Come on, I'm askin' ye!"

Russ and Enoch, battle-grimed and rent as to raiment, started for the cornered surfman. But Nathan snatched Russ by the arm and flung him back, and stepped between Enoch and Aubrey.

“You stay out o’ this!” he commanded his offspring. “This Sears—he needs a dose o’ the medicine such as only one o’ my generation can hand him. I’ll take care o’ him in the good old-fashioned way. You three go back to the dories an’ see ’at no one swipes our lobsters.”

With a rush, the big fisherman resumed the conflict. Nathan was fighting, now, with knees as well as fists—the kind of fighting the old-time Yankee skippers resorted to when all other methods of subduing refractory members of their crews failed. In his younger days Nathan Holway had earned the nickname of “Bloody Nathan” from his proficiency in this style of fighting. Aubrey had seen Cap Cole fight that way once when he half killed a crazy-drunk sailor, so he knew what to expect.

He avoided Bloody Nathan by sidestepping, smashing left and right uppercuts to the fisherman’s lowered face. But the endurance of that hulk of bone and muscle was nothing short of marvelous, and he seemed to be wholly unaffected.

Now and then Aubrey felt the impact of Bloody Nathan’s huge fist as it smashed through his defense. Once Nathan’s knee caught the coast-guard in the abdomen, and he doubled up, seeing black. But he pulled himself together, and came back at his antagonist with a left to the jaw and a right uppercut to the chin, and again avoided the rush of the foul-fighting fisherman by sidestepping and smashing in with another left and right.

The pace was beginning to tell on Nathan. Aubrey’s wind was less expended, severely sapped though it was, for he didn’t waste energy in headlong rushes. One of Bloody Nathan’s eyes was closed, and his bleeding mouth lolled open. His lungs were wheezy and his knees shaky.

Then Aubrey rushed. He delivered a quick, swinging blow with his left that smashed through the fisherman’s awkward defense and crashed upon his bulbous nose. He groaned, and sank to the sand like a pole-axed steer.

The fall of their parent seemed to fire the three sons with fresh zeal. They pounced on Aubrey from all quarters, and he, his energy sapped by his vigorous fray with their father, went down on the sand under them, while they started to pummel him unmercifully.

But Aubrey twisted and squirmed clear of the three, leaving his undershirt in their clutches, and upsetting Fred, recovered his footing. He

knew he was licked; the fight with Nathan had taken too much out of him to go through it all over again with them. But no matter how badly he was mauled, his was the satisfaction of making Bloody Nathan take the count. Mamie, wherever she was, couldn't accuse him of being a coward now. Neither could Cap, whatever Cap would think of his judgment in starting the affair.

He didn't care about the Number One surfman's job now. Nor did Mamie seem a vital factor in his life. She had got him into this mess. It would be interesting to find out whether she would stick to him or not if the Number One job went to some one else.

He was standing again with his back to the harbor, the three sons of Bloody Nathan facing him but not carrying the fight to him. Near by he could make out Mamie trying to reach him, but Amos and Emma were holding her back.

"Come on, yuh damned coward!" Aubrey taunted Russ.

"Come on yerself!" retorted Russ.

"Start somethin'!" squealed Enoch.

And Aubrey accepted the invitation by charging Russ, head down, blindly, adopting Bloody Nathan's method of attack—a method which had vindicated itself in free-for-all fighting. Again and again he flailed his fists at the fisherman's eldest son, who gave no ground, but stood resigned to his punishment, if punishment it really were which Aubrey, in his exhausted state, was administering.

He was gripped by the shoulder and drawn firmly back, his fists fanning the air.

"Sears—behave! You've gone fur enough with this!"

Aubrey weakly raised his head—and his one open eye took in Cap Cole, holding his shoulder with one strong hand gripping what appeared to be the cylindrical metal case of a beach-torch in the other.

"I aint—gone fur—enough!" Aubrey defied his commander, struggling feebly and unsuccessfully to wrench himself loose. "I aint—*begun*—to fight!"

“It’s all his doin’, Cap!” groaned Bloody Nathan, staggering out of the fog to the Santuck commander, while his three sons retreated to the two dories. “Sears interfered with us, Cap—in the name o’ the coast-guard—out o’ spite to keep us from gittin’ a decent night’s rest—him in plain clothes—with no authority—”

“Why are you makin’ such a spectacle o’ yerself ag’inst a law-abidin’ citizen like Nathan?” Cole severely questioned the young surfman. “It’s a good thing Amos Swift called me up an’ told me you was in hot water at the landin’, judgin’ by the loud talk he heard. If you had your pistol here, I cal’late they’d ’a’ been murder committed—with you in your present frame o’ mind. If Jansen wa’n’t on patrol an’ he’d come here with me—”

“Yeah,” Aubrey flung back. “It’s always Jansen. ’Twas him that lied about me that night on Salt Marsh. An’ you’re no better’n he is, to b’lieve him, an’ send that lyin’ report to the superintendent!” He reached into his hip pocket, drew an automatic pistol, and handed it to Cap, holding it by the barrel. “Here’s my gun, Cap,” he said. “It’s been in my pants pocket all durin’ the scrap.”

Cap accepted the weapon without comment, relinquishing his grip on Aubrey’s shoulder.

“I’m through with the damn’ coast-guard an’ Santuck!” Aubrey thus kicked over the traces and stove in the dashboard. “Through with you, an’ Jansen, an’ your lies ’bout me. I’m going to sea—inland—*anywhere* to git away from you two. I told you the truth that night on Salt Marsh. An’ what did *you* do? You believed what Jansen told yuh, an’ worse’n that—you put it in the report to headquarters, an’ it got in the paper. I done tonight what I set out to do—I’ve got *that* much satisfaction out of it, no matter how big a fool you an’ the Howesport folks call me!”

A small hand tenderly dabbed at his empurpled eye with a tiny handkerchief.

“Good for you, Aubrey!” Mamie applauded. “We wont change our plans a mite, Aubrey, you ’n’ me. We’ll git along somehow—I’ll go through anything to make you happy.” She turned savagely on Cap. “The idea o’ you belittlin’ my Aubrey after he’s been—so brave—” A sob choked her.

But Cap laughed, and again laid his hand on Aubrey's shoulder. "You're *not* goin' to leave the coast-guard, Sears!" he declared. "You're goin' to be the nex' Number One surfman at Santuck station, if I have anything to say about it—an' I cal'late I will! You don't s'pose for a minute that I believed Jansen after he put that piece in the Boston paper, do ye? That wa'n't what I reported to the superintendent. I didn't mention your name in that report. An' when I seen that newspaper, I telephoned it to find out where they got the information, an' they said 'From Jansen.' He didn't have no authority to put that in without gittin' me to endorse it. It's an open vi'lotion o' discipline, an' it's proof to me that he aint to be trusted. An' he wont command Sandy Holler if *I* c'n help it, by golly!"

"Then why didn't you tell Aubrey that today?" indignantly asked Mamie.

"Because," Cap replied, "I wanted to have somethin' better to report to the superintendent 'bout Sears before I recommended him for Jansen's place. An' I cal'lated the best way to stir him up so's I could do that would be to make him think he's wuth less'n a healthy damn, an' git his fightin' dander up."

"I can't see whar he *is* wuth more'n that," spoke up Nathan, who had recovered sufficiently from his mauling to listen interestedly to the conversation of Mamie and Cap. The glare of a flashlight down the beach revealed through the thinning fog the fisherman's three sons and four uniformed men of the Santuck crew grouped near the dories. "D'you coast-guard folks promote brave surfmen who pick on harmless fishermen an' damn' nigh beat the tar out of 'em?" he sneered.

"No—not for beatin' up *harmless* fishermen," countered Cap. "But for molestin' them engaged in *this* kind o' fishin'." He held up the metal cylinder.

Nathan swayed drunkenly when he looked at it, "Oh, hell!" he moaned. "I was dependin' on Russ an' the boys to take care o' that!"

"You was too busy fightin'—you an' your boys, Nathan—to notice my Santuck boys searchin' your lobsters," explained Cap. "This tube is full of opium. I'm familiar with it—it's the same kind the *Seabright's* been runnin'

ashore. Now I cal'late I know why Jansen advanced such good argymints to me to discontinue the Howesport harbor patrol. I cal'late his examination in court—an' yourn, too, Nathan—will be real interestin'!"

"Hereafter, Sears,"—he turned to Aubrey,—“what you say at Santuck station *goes*! That's final!"

Transcriber's note: This story appeared in the February, 1930 issue of *The Blue Book* magazine.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE COAST
GUARDSMAN ***

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